forward. For the first two time periods, we attempt to determine the impact that nuclear weapons had on Indo-Pakistani relations and the strategic environment on the subcontinent. For the future, we speculate as to how past proliferation-related developments may affect the South Asian strategic environment in years to come.

Nuclear proliferation's impact on South Asia is the subject of a growing literature. In this book we take an approach that differs from existing works on the subject. First, we assess the issue of South Asian proliferation not from a single vantage point, but rather from two competing perspectives. Thus, although we examine the same historical evidence, we come to very different conclusions regarding nuclear weapons' impact on the subcontinent. Ganguly believes that nuclear weapons helped stabilize the regional security environment in the past; are to a large degree responsible for recent improvements in Indo-Pakistani strategic relations; and will help ensure that current improvements continue into the future. His argument is straightforward: Because nuclear weapons threaten to make conflict catastrophically costly, they induce caution in New Delhi and Islamabad. This has led the two sides to defuse ongoing crises without resorting to large-scale war and to take steps toward improving their larger strategic relationship. These factors have contributed to the current thaw in Indo-Pakistani relations and should continue to stabilize the subcontinent in coming years.

Kapur, in contrast, argues that nuclear weapons had a destabilizing effect on the South Asian security environment in the past; have little to do with recent improvements in Indo-Pakistani relations; and may destabilize South Asia in the future. Kapur maintains that nuclear weapons have had two negative effects on the South Asian security environment. First, nuclear weapons' ability to shield Pakistan against all-out Indian retaliation, and to attract international attention to Pakistan's dispute with India, encouraged aggressive Pakistani behavior. This, in turn, provoked forceful Indian responses, ranging from large-scale mobilization to limited war. Second, these Indo-Pakistani crises led India to adopt a more aggressive military posture toward Pakistan. This development could exacerbate regional security-dilemma dynamics and increase the likelihood of Indo-Pakistani conflict in years to come.